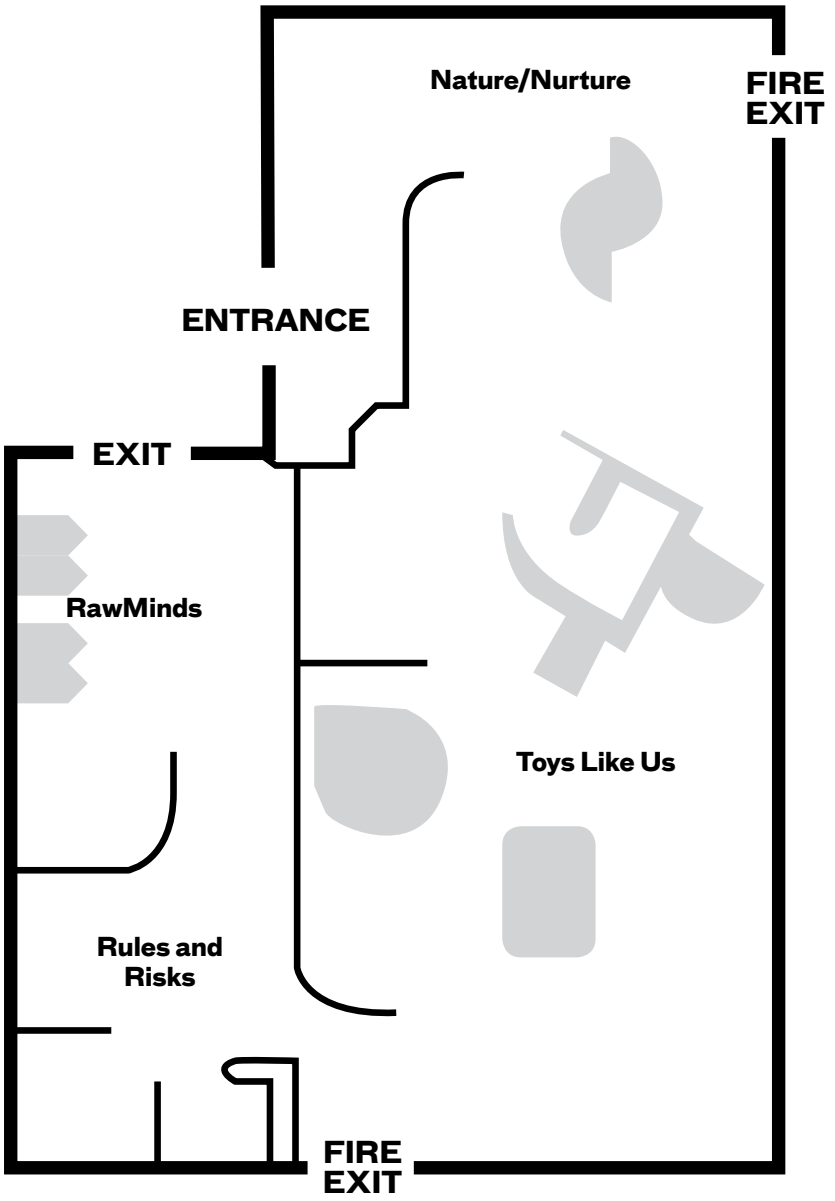
wellcome collection

PLAY WELL

Why play matters

24 October 2019—8 March 2020

Gallery map


Nature/Nurture
FIRE EXIT
ENTRANCE
EXIT
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Toys Like Us
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FIRE EXIT

PLAY WELL

Why do we play? How important is it for all of us, young or old? This exhibition examines the significance of play both in childhood and across society at large. It explores the joyful instinct to play and its role in learning, as well as the importance of play in developing social bonds, emotional resilience and physical wellbeing.

Often set against the more serious business of work, *Play Well* makes the case for play as an essential tool, crucial in developing and refining character traits and skills like self-esteem, cooperation and problem-solving. It shows how play can serve as a retreat from trauma and how it can be employed as a language to express emotions and build empathy.

How and where children play both reflects and adapts to the world around them. Playground games and toys echo shifts in wider society, while spaces for play are limited by concerns about risk. In light of these influences we ask: how can we all play well?

The exhibition design for *Play Well* has been developed with children aged 5–11 from Argyle Primary School in Camden. RawMinds, a group of young people aged 14–19, have designed digital games for the exhibition.



Stockport, 1966. Shirley Baker.
© Nan Levy for the Estate of Shirley Baker

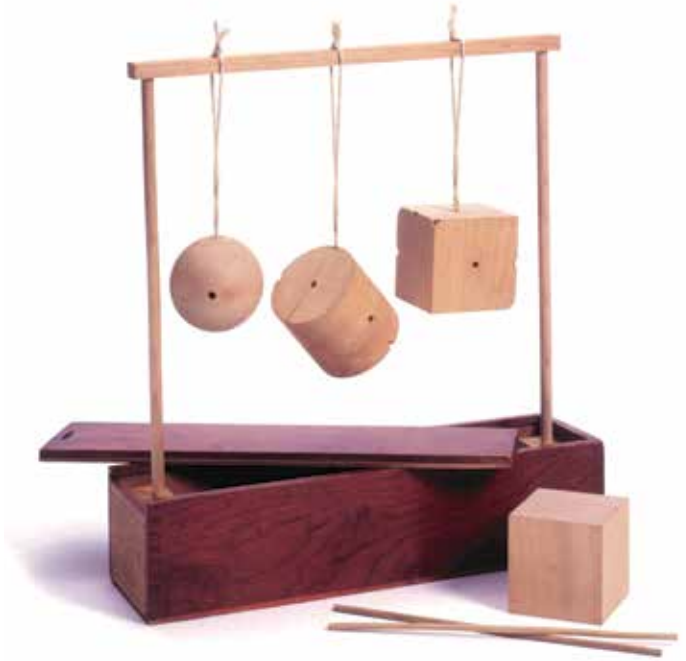
NATURE/NURTURE

Play is essential for learning about the world, as well as providing the physical and psychological benefits of having fun. The urge to play isn't exclusive to humans but can also be seen in many animals. It is an instinct that is not learned, but does require the right conditions to flourish.

Philosophers and educators have long argued for the value of play in education, encouraging learning through child-led interactions with the world rather than formal teaching. The founder of the Kindergarten movement, Friedrich Fröbel (1782–1852), described play as the "highest expression of human development in childhood, for it alone is the free expression of what is in a child's soul".

Fröbel devised a series of objects that he called the Gifts, and a set of guided activities, known as the Occupations. There were 20 different Gifts, made of simple materials, each designed as a progression for specific stages of development. The first was for the youngest infant, aged six to eight weeks old. Later Gifts took geometrical forms which could be explored in a variety of different ways. This went on to have a lasting impact on 20th-century art education and creative practice.

Architect Frank Lloyd Wright wrote of the importance of his encounters with Fröbel's Gifts: "The smooth shapely maple blocks with which to build, the sense of which never afterwards leaves the fingers: so form became feeling. And the box with a mast to set upon it, on which to hang with string the maple cubes and spheres and triangles, revolving them to discover subordinate forms."



Fröbel's Gift 2: Sphere, Cylinder and Cube, *c.*1890. *Collection of Elyse and Lawrence B. Benenson*

The 20th century has been called "the century of the child", an era in which childhood experience came to the fore. This was reflected in early education practice. In 1917, Rachel and Margaret McMillan set up the first nursery school for London's most impoverished children. The McMillan sisters were determined to create a clean and welcoming environment, which would encourage the children's "play-instinct".

In the immediate aftermath of World War II, a group of citizens in a village in Reggio Emilia, northern Italy, sold an abandoned army tank and built a school in Villa Cella. It was the first in what was to become a thriving network of preschools. The Reggio Emilia Approach acknowledges the child as author of their own knowledge and experience, placing play and experimentation at the forefront of learning. This approach to learning and play has had an international influence which continues to grow.



The first Reggio Emilia infant-toddler centre, Genoeffa Cervi, opens in 1971.
Archive of Documentation and Educational Research Centre, Preschool and Infant-Toddler Centres – Istituzione of the Municipality of Reggio Emilia

The emotional need to play was a key feature of 20th-century child psychiatry and psychology. Many children were left orphaned, displaced or traumatised in the aftermath of World Wars I and II. Margaret Lowenfeld (1890–1973) was a British paediatrician, child psychologist and psychoanalyst who pioneered the use of play therapy in the interwar years.

D.W. Winnicott (1896–1971) was a child psychiatrist and paediatrician who trained as a child psychoanalyst during the 1920s. A playful man, he used various games to facilitate communication between child and therapist. One such technique was the squiggle game. In this "game with no rules", Winnicott and his client would take turns to make an abstract "squiggle" drawing, which the other could then make into anything they wanted. A process of collaborative storytelling would take place, which would allow further conversations and reveal insights into the child's life.

The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child in 1989 declared play as a basic human need, placing an obligation on nation states to respect, protect and fulfil children's right to play. The development NGO BRAC conducts rigorous academic research into the importance of play in early childhood experience. Their Play Labs provide opportunities in lower-income countries to access play-based learning. These spaces are carefully designed using materials that reference local culture, and are zoned into different areas of activity. In total, there are over 800 Play Labs operating today.

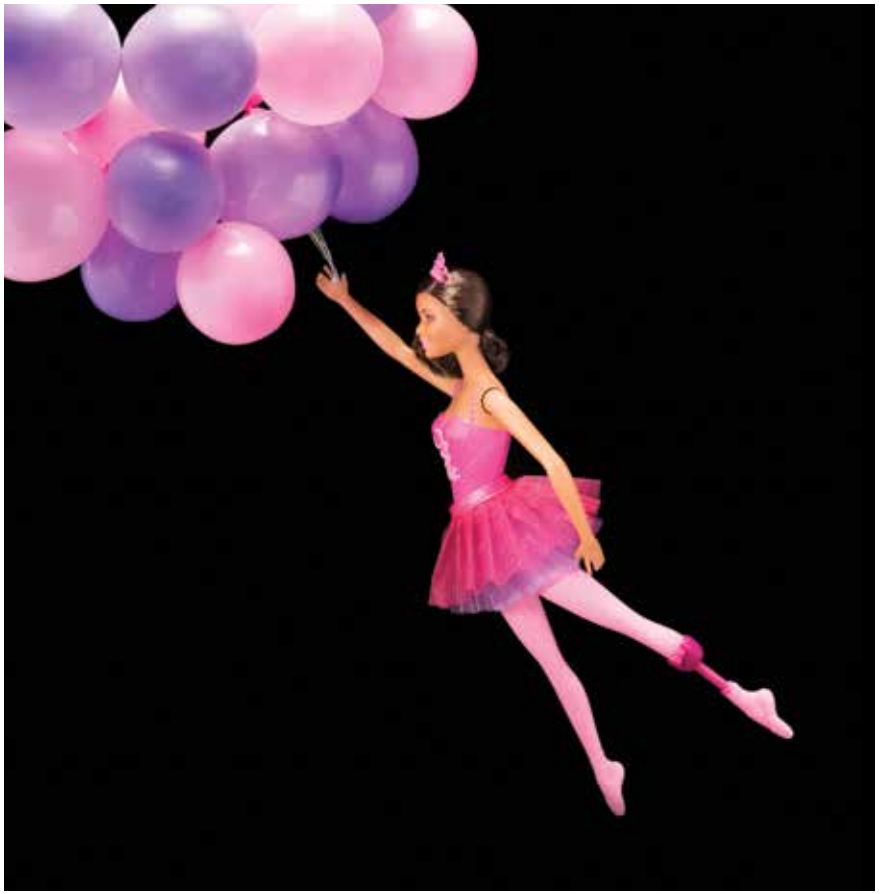
In 2018 BRAC set up Play Labs in a humanitarian setting for the first time, in the Rohingya refugee camps in Bangladesh. Play Labs provide displaced children with security and a safe space for them to reclaim their childhood. BRAC Humanitarian Play Labs foster the healing, development, empathy and dignity of a vulnerable community, within a protective space, through play and cultural retention. Unlike the Play Labs elsewhere, these are temporary structures but are still carefully designed. The exterior of the play space is demarcated by wall drawings by the children. Wall drawings are important in Rohingya culture and help to provide a sense of home in the camps.



Squiggle drawing, *c.*1950–71. D.W. Winnicott and a client.
Wellcome Collection



Healing through physical play, 2019. Sheikh Shananuzzaman Angkan.
BRAC Institute of Educational Development



Barbie with prosthetic limb, 2016.
#ToyLikeMe/Beth Moseley/ Rebecca Atkinson/Kate Read

TOYS LIKE US

Children's play absorbs and reflects trends in wider society. Imaginative role-play allows children to assume different identities and points of view, exploring power dynamics through make-believe. Playground chants and rhymes provide an insight into the ways cultural influences are transmitted and understood through play. Popular culture, gender politics and digital gaming are incorporated into more traditional games, which evolve according to the place and time in which they are played.

Toys also echo these societal shifts, as well as demonstrating other influences like the availability of new materials and pressure of market forces. The power of imagination can transform a stick into a horse, but what role does it play in today's market of increasingly elaborate and franchised toys?

Reacting against the narrow stereotypes represented by toys like Barbie and GI Joe, campaigners are increasingly calling for diversity in toy design. Positive, incidental representations of disability can boost the self-esteem of children who see their own experience reflected in their toys, as well as encouraging friendships irrespective of difference.

Frustrated by the lack of representation of children with disabilities in the toy market, journalist Rebecca Atkinson founded the creative collective #ToyLikeMe. Making over mainstream toys to show a range of human difference, #ToyLikeMe has called on the toy industry to better represent disability in children's everyday lives.

RULES AND RISK

Risk is an important part of childhood play, offering children the opportunity to challenge themselves physically, emotionally and mentally. But societal rules and changing attitudes to risk can limit freedom to play. In postwar Britain, children found new playgrounds among the bombsites and widespread demolition. As well as providing exciting places for play, these largely unsupervised spaces gave children a place to manage conflict and competition – as well as form friendships and care for others. The adventure playground movement sought to preserve this kind of risky play, and to protect access to nature in an era of increasing urbanisation and privatisation of public space. Originally set up in the 1950s, the mission of adventure playgrounds remains crucial today.

Some adventure playgrounds are today under threat due to scant funding, increasing regulation and disappearing urban space. Artist and activist Mark Neville's photographs of adventure playgrounds around London were part of a wider project to defend children's rights to play. Neville makes a connection between "shrinking childhoods" and the rise of mental health problems among children and young people. His book *Child's Play*, including images of children at play across the world, was sent out to key policy makers and all UK local councils to advocate for a national strategy for play.

As physical play has diminished, so digital play has increased. The rapid increase in video gaming over recent decades has led to concerns over gaming addiction, which was classified as a disease by the World Health Organization in 2018. But digital play also gives children freedom to have fun and make social connections in today's world.

"Better a broken bone than a broken spirit"

Marjory Allen



Arts and Crafts at Somerford Grove Adventure Playground, London, 2011. Mark Neville. *Courtesy of the artist*

RawMinds game design

As the popularity of gaming has increased, so have anxieties about its impact on health. We asked a group of young people aged 14–19 to create games based on their experiences as “digital natives” – the generation brought up in the digital age – and to consider both positive and negative aspects of gaming. They were led by game designer Adam Dixon and met a range of industry professionals, including a psychologist studying the short- and long-term behavioural effects of video gaming. The resulting games reflect their opinions on gaming as a way of forging friendships and enabling collaboration, as well as concerns about anxiety and addiction.

RawMinds projects take place twice a year at Wellcome Collection, and offer young people aged 14–19 opportunities to experiment with art and science, get creative and learn new skills in their spare time.

Commission

Artist Adam James uses larp (live action role-play) to explore how play can promote empathy and collaboration. Larp is a form of collaborative storytelling in which players, who otherwise might not know each other, assume a character and immerse themselves in a fiction to experience how others might live. For the exhibition, James has created an environment which invites playful responses to somewhat ambiguous objects, reminiscent of postwar playgrounds and childish desires.

Interact with these forms as you see fit. Sit on them, move them or work together to make new structures.

Gallery games led by staff will take place in this space throughout the exhibition.

Events

On 11–12 January and 15–16 February 2020, there will be free weekend play events across the building. Some activities will be ticketed in advance.

Find out more:
wellcomecollection.org

Book

When did you last make time for play? Former children’s laureate and bestselling author, Michael Rosen, is here to show us how to get more play in our lives – and why it matters so much for creativity, resilience and much more.

Packed with silliness, activities and prompts for creative indoor and outdoor play for all ages.

Please recycle unwanted guides at the end of the exhibition using the box provided

Wellcome Collection is a free museum and library inspired by the medical objects collected by Henry Wellcome. It connects science, medicine, life and art. Through its exhibitions, live programming, and digital and publishing activity, it makes thought-provoking content which aims to challenge how we all think and feel about health.

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Opening hours

Galleries are open 10.00–18.00 Tuesday–Saturday (Thursdays until 21.00) and 10.00–18.00 on Sunday.

Galleries are closed on Mondays (except bank holidays).

#PlayWell

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